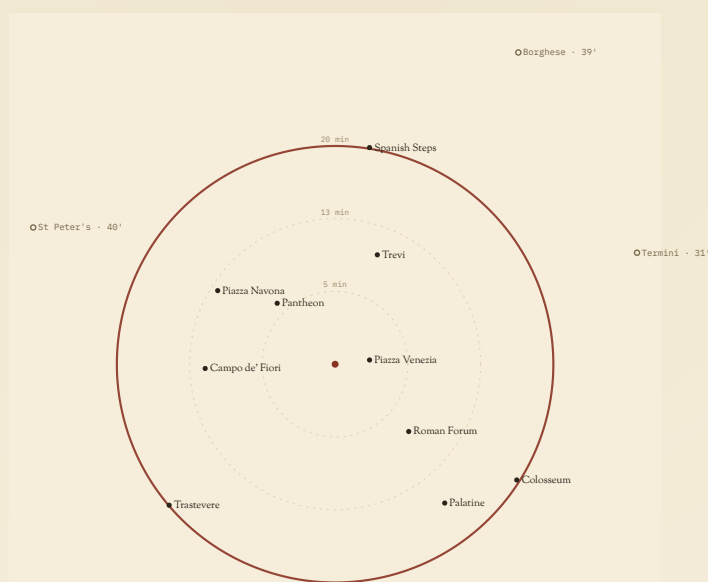


of the quarters you'll walk. And a short companion sheet carries the figures that change, so this book can hold only what lasts. Read it once, cover to cover, in an evening. Then carry the wallet card and the Field Sheet, and let the forty tabs stay closed.

Rome, Solved.

*Which of it is actually worth your time —
and which is the photo everyone regrets.*



The historic core is a kilometre and a half across.
You walk it. This book is that one fact, worked out.

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The ground: a city you can walk across

One fact reorganises the whole trip — the historic core is about a kilometre and a half across.

Here is the fact the rest of this book is built on. Rome's historic centre — the connected core that holds almost every sight a first-timer comes for — is far smaller than it looks on a map. The Pantheon, the Trevi Fountain, Piazza Navona, the Spanish Steps, Campo de' Fiori, the Forum and the Colosseum all sit inside a pedestrian district you can cross on foot in well under an hour. • From its centre near Piazza Venezia, the farthest of those sights — the Colosseum, the Spanish Steps, the edge of Trastevere — are about twenty minutes' walk. The dense heart of it, the Pantheon and the piazzas, is closer to ten.

Two structural facts make walking not merely possible but the only sensible way around. The metro deliberately skirts the historic centre — you cannot tunnel freely under two millennia of ruins — so the core has no line beneath it, and cars are restricted or unwelcome in the tangle of pedestrian lanes. • On foot is genuinely the fastest way through the centre, and it is also the richest: walk from the Pantheon to the Trevi and you pass fountains, churches with Caravaggios hung in the gloom, artisan workshops and tiny piazzas you'd never have planned to see. In Rome the walking is not the overhead between sights. It is the sightseeing.

Internalise that one measurement and the daunting city becomes a small one, and half the trip's decisions answer themselves. You sleep in the core because the core is walkable (Decision 01). You skip the transit pass because you won't ride enough to justify it (Decision 02). You take the fixed-fare taxi from the airport because it delivers you into that walkable heart (Decision 03). You eat two streets off the monuments because the core is small enough that two streets is a different city (Decision 08). Every one of those calls is the same kilometre-and-a-half fact, pointed at a different question. The one real exception — the Vatican, across the river, a genuine ride or a long walk away — is exactly why it gets its own half-day rather than sharing the ancient core's (Decision 04).

Where should you actually sleep?

The most consequential booking you make — and the instinct that ruins it is treating a metro address as an upgrade.

Rome's historic core is roughly a kilometre and a half across, and its outer edges — the Colosseum, Trastevere, the Spanish Steps — sit about twenty minutes' walk from the centre. • The classic sights a first-timer comes for are not scattered across a metropolis; they are one connected pedestrian district you cross on foot in well under an hour. That single fact should decide where you sleep — and it quietly overturns the booking logic most Americans arrive with.

The instinct is reasonable and wrong. You are told, correctly, that the streets around Termini station hold Rome's densest concentration of hotels, at the city's best prices, with both metro lines and the airport train on the doorstep. • So you book there to save money and “stay near the transport.” The flaw is that the transport you are buying access to cannot reach the sights you came for. Rome's metro deliberately skirts the historic centre — you cannot tunnel freely under two thousand years of ruins — so the heart of the city has no line under it at all. • A Termini base puts you next to the one tool that doesn't serve the place you're going.

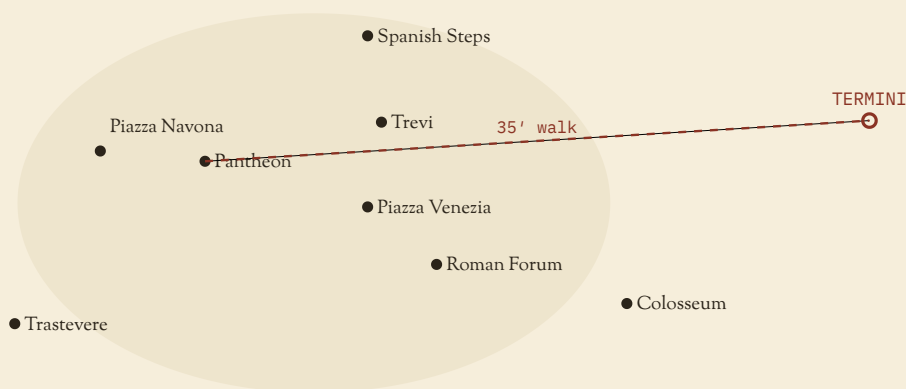


FIG. 3 • The walkable core with the classic sights inside it, and Termini's 35-minute walk to the Pantheon drawn to scale. The “best-transport” base sits outside the district it's meant to serve.

Do the walk instead of the maths. From a hotel by Termini, the Pantheon is a thirty-five-minute walk and Piazza Navona closer to forty; from Centro Storico or Monti, the centre of the core is about thirteen. The €30 you saved on the room buys you an hour of daily commuting — by metro to a station that still leaves you a walk short, or on

foot across the least interesting part of the centre. You did not save money. You spent it in the currency the trip is actually short of, which is unhurried time inside the walls.

This is why the neighbourhood, not the hotel, is the decision. A merely adequate room in the core beats a beautiful one outside it, because on a three-day first trip the walk home at midnight — past a floodlit fountain, through a lane of wine bars — is not travel overhead. It is the thing you came for. The base decides how much of that you get.

THE BASES, SCORED · FIRST-TIME AMERICAN, 3 NIGHTS

WALK TO CORE	CHARACTER	PRICE
Centro Storico — postcard Rome, walk to all •		13'
Monti — local feel, steps from the Forum •		13'
Trastevere — charm and dinners, a bridge over •		20'
Prati — calm, elegant, Vatican-side •		38'
Near Termini — cheapest, best transport, gritty •		28'

THE CALL

Sleep inside the core; treat a metro address as a downgrade, not a discount. For a first trip of three or four days, book Centro Storico if the budget allows and Monti if it doesn't — both put the centre thirteen minutes' walk away. Choose Trastevere only if evenings matter more than mornings, and accept the bridge. Termini is a fine place to change trains and a poor place to wake up.

FOLLOW THIS IF

- you want the classic sights, and you're here three or four days
→ Centro Storico or Monti
- evenings and atmosphere outrank proximity to the ruins → Trastevere, bridge and all

OVERRIDE IT IF

- you're here to do serial day-trips by rail and barely see Rome
→ Termini earns its place
- you specifically want a large full-service hotel → the core has few; Prati or Termini have them

The €-figures move; the walk-times don't. ♦ Room rates by area and season live on the Field Sheet. The distances above are ours, measured on foot. ▲ SURVEYED 07/26.

→ the transit maths that follows from this → Decision 02



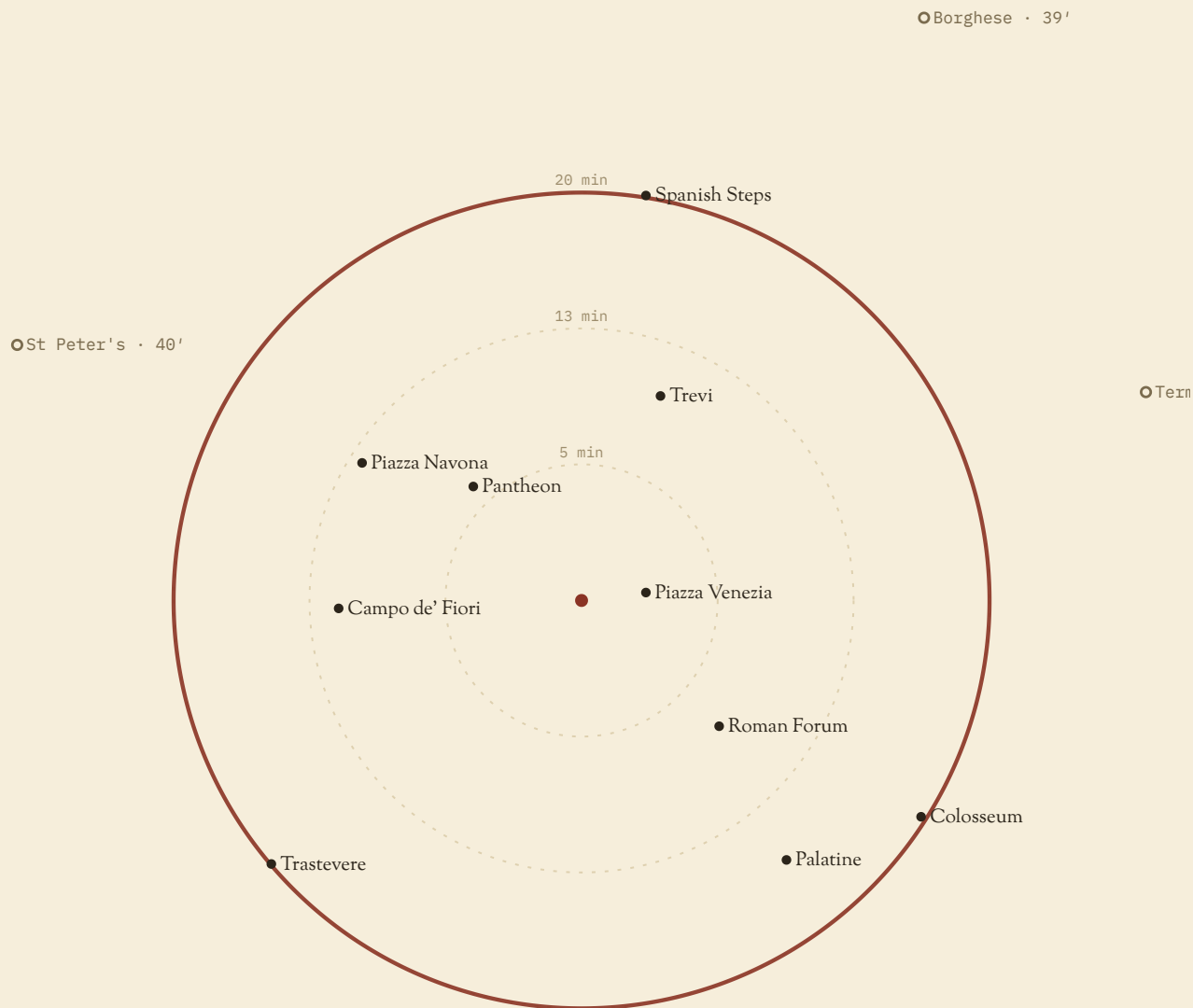


FIG. 1 · The classic-sights core drawn to real walk-times: a 1.5km ring from Piazza Venezia contains everything a first-timer comes for, with the Colosseum and Spanish Steps on its rim at ≈20 minutes. Termini and the Vatican sit outside it – which is the whole argument.

It's worth meeting the obvious objection head-on, because it's a fair one: isn't Rome an enormous city? It is — a sprawling modern metropolis of nearly three million people, with suburbs and ring roads and a second airport. But the Rome a first-timer comes to see is not that city; it's the compact historic core the tourist map actually covers, and that core is the kilometre and a half we've measured. The confusion between the two — planning for the



PL. 1 • The compact core at golden hour — the Colosseum and the churches of the historic centre within a single frame. This is the kilometre and a half the whole book turns on: not a metropolis to be commuted across, but a district you walk.

The Field Sheet

The volatile figures, dated. Everything that moves lives here, not in the Book.

Method: the figures below are the ones that change — fares, booking windows, an exchange reference. Verified values are marked as of their month; anything we could not verify at press time is listed as “confirm in your travel week,” with the official source to check named. Never a blank cell. When the Sheet and the Book disagree, the Sheet is newer and wins.

GETTING IN FROM FIUMICINO

Leonardo Express (non-stop to Termini)	≈ €14 one-way, ~32 min, every ~15 min — confirm at trenitalia.com
FL1 regional (Trastevere/Ostiense/Tiburtina, not Termini)	≈ €8 — confirm at trenitalia.com
Fixed-fare official taxi to inside the Aurelian Walls	€55 flat, up to 4 (raised 2026) — posted at the rank

PASSES & TRANSIT

Single ticket (BIT, 100 min)	confirm current fare — atac.roma.it
Contactless daily fare cap	auto-caps at the 24h pass price — confirm at atac.roma.it
Roma Pass / Omnia Card price & inclusions	confirm before buying — romapass.it / official Omnia site
Unvalidated-ticket fine	€100+ on the spot — validate paper, or tap a card

THE SIGHTS THAT SELL OUT

Vatican Museums — booking window & fee	sells out ~weeks in peak — tickets.museivaticani.va
Borghese Gallery — mandatory timed slot	book on sale — galleriaborghese.it
Colosseum Standard & Full Experience	Full Experience ~weeks, guided-only — colosseo.it
Pantheon timed entry	confirm current fee/slot — official Pantheon ticketing
First-Sunday free-entry dates	Domenica al Museo — confirm the month's date

MONEY

USD-EUR reference rate	check in your travel week — a bank/FX source
The rule that never moves	at any reader, choose EUROS, never dollars